

you make to lose weight after the birth. You'll feel extremely tired in the first few months of taking care of a newborn, and you may not feel up to doing much exercise other than taking your baby out for a walk in the stroller. But that's fine—gentle walking is wonderful exercise and there's no need to push yourself any harder than that. The most important thing is to try not to rush the process. Furthermore,

making milk for your baby if you're breast-feeding uses a lot of energy, so you'll need to increase your calorie intake to keep going. In general terms, if getting back to your pre-pregnancy weight is a priority for you, think of your weight loss according to the old adage "nine months up, nine months down." Give yourself all that time to get back to where you want to be. Don't get frustrated if it takes you

longer—some women take many years to regain their pre-pregnancy weight, often out of choice, waiting until they've completed their family so that they only have to think about weight loss once. Of course, some women also slip right back into their skinny jeans after birth. You're wonderfully lucky—and incredibly unusual—if that turns out to be the case for you.

Q How much of my weight gain is caused by my baby and how much of it is just me?

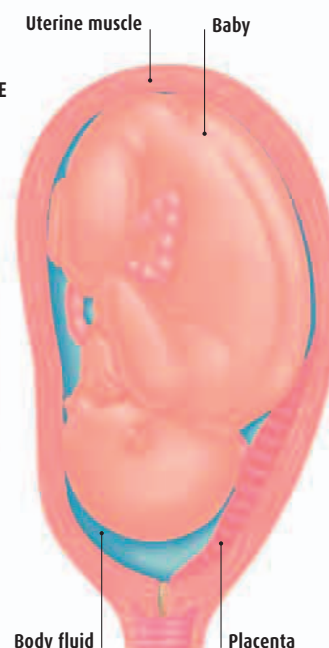
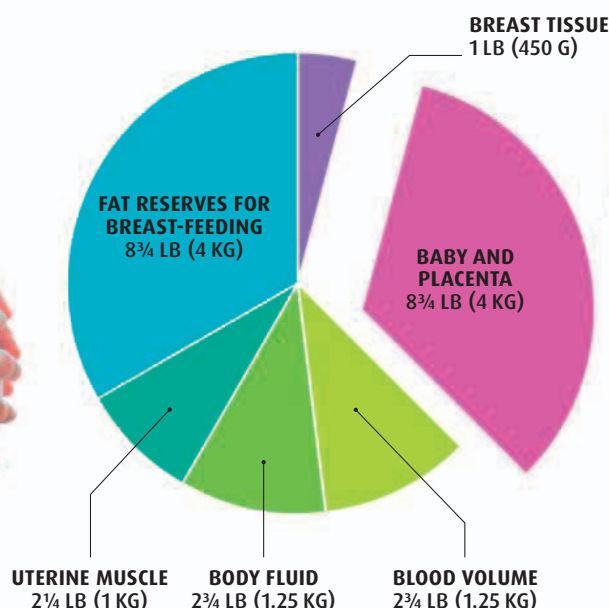
About a third of your pregnancy weight gain is your baby and the placenta, but that doesn't mean that two-thirds of it is you—or at least it's not "bad-for-you" you.

That two-thirds is made up of increased blood and fluid plumping up your cells; you also have more muscle around your uterus (it helps you to get the baby out), and the increase in progesterone and estrogen mean that your breasts grow larger and therefore heavier even before you start making

milk. You also have increased fat reserves (usually around your hips) to prepare you for making milk and breast-feeding. All of these elements of your weight gain are positive, natural, and nothing to worry about. Try to welcome your curvier hips, larger breasts, and glorious skin. They are beautiful signs that your body is doing its job of nourishing your baby.

WHERE THE "PREGNANCY WEIGHT" GOES

A woman who gains 26½ lb (12 kg) in weight during her pregnancy will have that gain distributed roughly like this:



Change over the trimesters
Your baby and its placenta will grow; however, the fluid around your baby will reduce.

Growing belly As it grows you will notice other parts of your body changing too. Try to enjoy this time.

Key areas The increase in volume and weight supports and nourishes your growing baby.

